

Storm deaths fell as the U.S. grew

The death rate from tornadoes, floods, and hurricanes is much lower than it was in the 1940s. That is good news. It does not mean the danger is gone.

Walter McDonald · University of Rochester · Data through 2023

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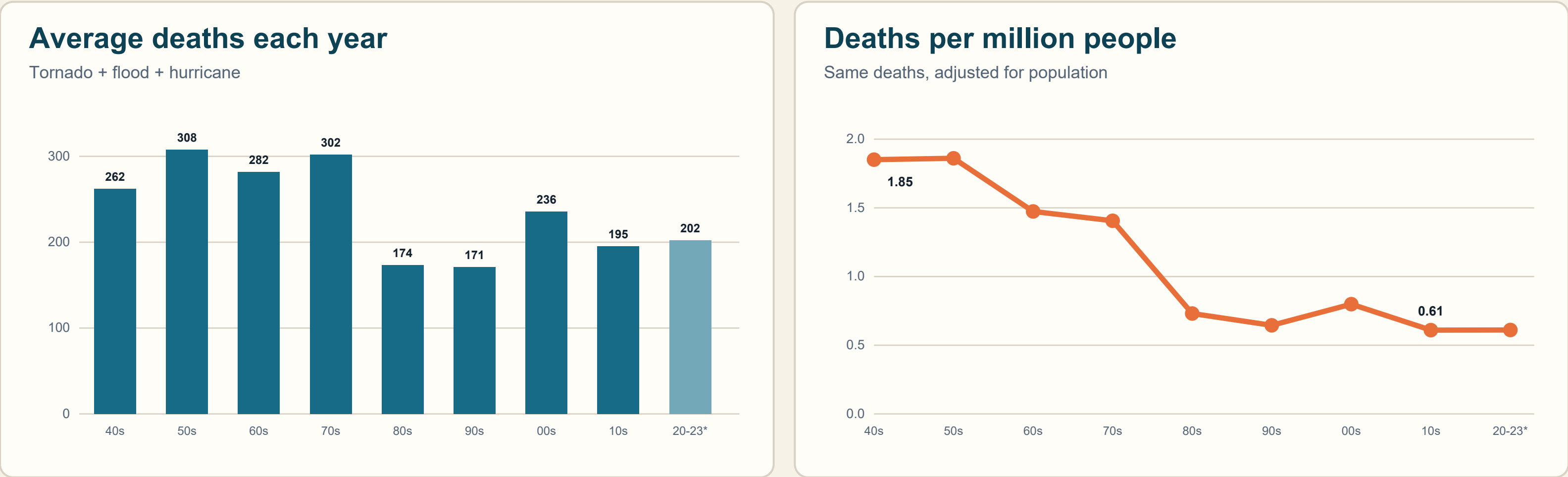
deaths a year in the 1940s

195

deaths a year in the 2010s

-67%

change in deaths per million



Why the denominator matters: The U.S. population more than doubled. The raw count fell about one fourth. The rate per million fell about two thirds. The count shows how many lives were lost. The rate gives a fairer comparison across time.

People still move toward risk

Net domestic migration, 2020-21

Florida		262k
Texas		183k
North Carolina		79k

All three states face hurricane risk. But a move into a state is not proof of a move into a floodplain or hurricane zone.

Risk is more than weather

The IPCC found that more people and property in exposed places were the main cause of long-run growth in disaster losses. People may accept more risk for jobs, family, warm weather, lower taxes, or cheaper homes.

Economics: Strong roofs, flood maps, warnings, and steady power may save lives. But making a place safer can also draw in more building. Policy should show the cost and avoid making other people pay for a risk they did not choose.

Do not mix two different death measures

The Burke team estimates that hot and cold temperatures may play a part in 5% to 12% of all deaths in the countries they study. These statistical estimates are not the same as NWS reports tied to named storms. Many heat plans lack strong proof. Home weatherization helped some health outcomes, but saved less energy than expected.

But wait: Falling death rates do not prove every safety program worked. The data leave out injuries, lost homes, stress, and money lost. Records may also be better today. My claim is narrow: the U.S. got much better at keeping people alive during these three storm hazards.

The storm matters, but so do our choices about where we live, what we build, and how we prepare.

Sources: NWS, 80-Year List of Severe Weather Fatalities (1940-2023), [weather.gov/media/hazstat/80years_2023.pdf](https://www.weather.gov/media/hazstat/80years_2023.pdf) · U.S. Census, Historical Population Change Data · IRS, Pub. 5508 (2020-21 migration) · Burke et al., NBER Working Paper 34313 (2025) · IPCC SREX (2012). Decade population = midpoint of Census counts. 2020-23 is a partial period.

